

DIVIDING THE NATION

The MNS chief plays to the Maharashtrian gallery but the ramifications are both evil and dangerous

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A statue of the Great Maratha warrior king Chhatrapati Shivaji in a classic battle pose dominates Shivaji Park, a spear's throw from Raj Thackeray's residence. The Maharashtra

Navnirman Sena (MNS) leader, like his uncle Bal Thackeray, frequently flaunts Shivaji's name to rally voters at his public meetings in Maharashtra. The distortion of history is conveniently ignored. Shivaji fought and defeated powerful Mughal invaders to create a unified India, albeit a Hindu one. Raj Thackeray is doing the opposite: dividing India by unleashing his goon squads on fellow Indians, with fatal consequences, just because they happen to come from outside the state. The strategy to play to the Maharashtrian gallery and steal the vote bank from under his uncle's nose is obvious, but the ramifications are evil and dangerous. Having literally scented blood, his increasingly militant and mindless supporters are now indulging in open arson, destruction of property, and murder. The passenger from Bihar who was kicked and beaten on a train till he died is the latest manifestation of the

